

Threadweaver's Spellbook

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Master of Spellcraft, Thepyrgos

Under the seal of the Synod, Third Tier
Year of the Broken Crown

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Preface: A Letter to the Inquisitive

You have opened a book that should not exist. The Synod licenses texts on practical metaphysics; they do not license grimoires that teach the unsanctioned to set fires with a whisper. Yet here you are, and here I am, and the Weave is patient.

I am Lysandra of the Amber Gate. For thirty years I have taught Spellcraft at the University of Thepyrgos, and for thirty years I have watched students mispronounce [HEAL] and set their own sleeves ablaze. This book is for the ones who survived. It is also for the ones who will not, because they will ignore every warning I write and leap toward danger with a grin. I salute those students. They are the ones who discover new tags.

What follows is a grammar of the raw Weave. You will find no incantations to memorise, no patron to beseech, no symbol to polish. You will find intention, tag, and consequence. The rest is practice.

I have divided the work into eight chapters. The first teaches the language of tags. The next four catalog spells by their purpose: humble cantrips, defensive arts, the unseen hand, and the elemental chorus. The sixth chapter is the one the Synod would burn: the dangerous door, where reality folds. The seventh chapter is a meditation on backlash—the Weave’s receipt for your ambition. The eighth chapter is advice on practice, because theory without sweat is a lecture without a desk.

The appendices that follow contain talents, builds, a complete tag reference, a lexicon of Thepyrgos slang, a collection of instructive failures, and an examination scenario for those who wish to test their skill. The Caster’s Ledger provides blank templates for recording your own spells.

If you are a student of the University, you may consider this a supplement to my lectures. If you are a hedge- mage without a patron, you may consider this a lifeline. If you are a Chain- Lantern inquisitor who has followed the paper trail to this page, you may consider it evidence. I will not hide.

The Weave does not care about your credentials. It only cares that you speak clearly.

— *Lysandra of the Amber Gate Thepyrgos, in the hour before the eighth bell*

1 The Grammar of the Weave

1.1 The Three Questions

Before you shape the Weave, you must answer three questions. I have asked them of a thousand students; I have heard a thousand stammers in reply. The questions are not difficult. The answers are.

1.1.1 First: What do you intend?

The Weave does not reward vagueness. *“I want to hurt him”* is a confession, not a spell. *“I want to sear his sword hand with a pinpoint of flame”* is an intention. The difference is precision. A lazy intent produces a lazy effect—or, worse, an effect that is precise in ways you did not intend.

Consider the novice who declared, *“I want to light the room.”* He chose [LIGHT]. He rolled. The room illuminated, yes, but so did his own hair. He spent the remainder of the examination with a faint, embarrassing glow. The Weave had answered exactly what he asked.

1.1.2 Second: Which tags serve your intent?

Tags are the verbs and nouns of the Weave’s grammar. You cannot shout *“fire”* and expect the universe to tremble. You must name the quality you wish to invoke.

I provide a reference in the appendix. For now, understand the families:

- **Elemental.** Burning, freezing, storm, stone, wave, wind. The loud spells. The ones that leave marks on the furniture.
- **Force.** Strike, area, wall, bind, dispel. The sculptors of raw arcane pressure.
- **Mind and Veil.** Veil, scry, memory, command, fear. The spells that make the Inquisition nervous.
- **Life and Body.** Heal, purify, strengthen, waken, beast. The spells that keep students alive between lectures.
- **Space and Motion.** Leap, fold, gate, gravity. The dangerous ones. I will speak of them in Chapter Six.
- **Creation and Transformation.** Create, summon, transmute, animate. The ones that make the Weave sigh.

A spell may carry one tag or several. Each tag adds a layer of meaning. *“I throw a [BURNING] [STRIKE] at the brigand”* is two tags. *“I throw a [BURNING] [STRIKE] [AREA] at the brigand and his companions”* is three. The Weave will accommodate you. It will also hold you responsible for the extra weight.

1.1.3 Third: What is the risk?

Every casting carries a price. The price is not in silver; it is in *receipts*. The Weave will answer. Whether the answer pleases you depends on the dice and the tag count.

Tags	The Weave's patience
One tag	The Weave is courteous. It expects little in return.
Two tags	The Weave is curious. It will watch you closely.
Three tags	The Weave is invested. It will remember.
Dangerous tag	The Weave is amused. It will add a surcharge.

I do not speak in numbers. Numbers are for clerks. But I will tell you this: a spell with one tag is a request. A spell with four tags is a negotiation. A spell with a dangerous tag is a dare. The Weave does not lose dares.

1.2 The Act of Casting

You have answered the three questions. Now you roll.

1.2.1 The Pool

Your dice pool is the sum of your relevant Attribute and your skill in Arcana. I do not prescribe which Attribute; that depends on your approach. A scholar invoking a precise flame uses Wits. A zealot calling down lightning uses Spirit. A performer veiling their face in a crowd uses Presence. The Weave does not care which muscle you flex, only that you flex it honestly.

1.2.2 The Target

The Game Master will set a Difficulty Value. This is not a secret. A competent caster should be able to estimate it before the dice leave their palm.

- A trivial working—lighting a candle, muffling a footstep—might require two successes.
- A standard combat spell—a blast of force, a binding of roots—requires three.
- A complex ritual—a short teleport, a veil over a crowd—requires four or more.

You will learn to gauge these numbers as you learn to gauge the weight of a wine jug. Experience, not theory.

1.2.3 The Dice

Roll. Count each die showing six or higher as a success. A ten counts twice. This is the Weave's opinion of your grammar.

Now look for the ones. Each die showing a one is a *story beat*—a gift to the Game Master. They will spend these gifts to complicate your success or deepen your failure. Do not resent them. A spell that works perfectly is a lecture you have already memorised. A spell that works with a twist is a lesson you will remember.

1.2.4 The Outcome

Compare your successes to the Difficulty Value.

- If you meet or exceed the target and rolled no ones, the Weave is satisfied. Your intent manifests cleanly.
- If you meet or exceed the target but rolled ones, the Weave is satisfied but curious. The Game Master will spend your story beats to add texture—a drifting spark, an echo of thunder, a moment of hesitation in an ally.
- If you fall short but still achieved at least one success, you have made progress. The Weave acknowledges your effort but expects more. You gain a boon—a token of momentum—to spend later.
- If you roll no successes at all, the Weave is not satisfied. It is not angry, merely disappointed. You gain two boons—the Weave's apology—and the Game Master will escalate the situation. Something will happen. It will not be what you wanted.

I have seen students weep at a miss. I have seen others laugh and spend their boons to re-roll a critical failure into a triumph. The dice do not judge. The Weave does not punish. The story continues.

1.3 A Note on Assistance

Two casters may weave together. One leads; the other supports. The supporting caster describes their aid—*“I steady her hands”* or *“I whisper the counter- rhythm to the Weave”*—and spends a boon to grant the lead caster an additional die. No more than three assistants may contribute to a single spell. The Weave has limits. So does the casting circle.

1.4 The Thepyrgos Lament

I add this for context, not instruction.

In the tower- clad streets of my home city, the Synod licenses magic. A Runekeeper's Codex is a permit; an Invoker's Symbol is a tax stamp. But a free caster—one who shapes the raw Weave without patron or writ—carries no paper trail. They are unaccountable. They are feared.

The Synod does not hunt the University don who practices Threadweaving in a sealed laboratory, surrounded by wards and graduate students. They hunt the gutter- mage who learned three tags from a dying grandmother and now improvises storms to pay his rent. The don is managed risk. The gutter- mage is wild risk. Both are free casters. The Weave does not distinguish.

If you carry this book, you may be considered the latter. I do not apologize. I only warn: cast with intention, but also with discretion. The Chain- Lanterns have long memories.

1.5 Summary for the Impatient

You intend. You name your tags. You roll Attribute plus Arcana against a Difficulty set by the Game Master. Successes are sixes and above; ones are story beats for the Game Master. Compare successes to difficulty, accept the outcome, and spend your boons.

The rest is practice. The rest is failure. The rest is reputation.

Now turn the page. The cantrips will not learn themselves.

2 Cantrips of the Humble Hand

2.1 The Small Work

Every master was once a student who could not light a candle without scorching the wick. I have scorched hundreds. The Weave forgives incompetence in small doses; it reserves its wrath for ambition without foundation.

Cantrips are spells of one tag. They are the alphabet of the Weave—individual letters, not yet words. A student who masters cantrips may still fail at greater workings, but a student who scorns cantrips will fail spectacularly. I have seen it. I have graded it.

2.1.1 On the Nature of Cantrips

A cantrip requires one tag, one intention, and a moment of focus. The Difficulty Value is two—the Weave’s lowest threshold. A competent caster with a pool of four or five dice will succeed more often than not. A novice will learn what failure tastes like. Both will improve.

The following table lists cantrips that have survived centuries of student misuse. I present them without apology for their modesty. A modest spell that works is worth a dozen ambitious spells that set fire to the syllabus.

Table 2.1: Common Cantrips of the Humble Hand

Spell	Tag	What It Does (in practice)
Ember Flick	[BURNING]	Ignites a small, unattended flammable object within Close range. A candle, a twist of paper, a dry leaf. Not a person. The Weave draws a line at arson.
Hush	[SILENCE]	Mutes all sound within a Close zone for a few heartbeats. A dropped key, a muttered curse, a footstep on a creaking stair—the Weave swallows them. The caster’s own voice is not muted. Some lessons are experiential.
Warmth	[HEAL]	Removes one point of Fatigue from the caster or a touched ally. The Weave does not knit flesh; it merely reminds the body that it is tired. A gentle spell. Often underestimated.

Table 2.1 – continued

Spell	Tag	What It Does (in practice)
Folded Sight	[VEIL]	Blurs the caster's features for a single exchange. Not invisibility. The observer sees a tradesman, a servant, a face they will not remember. The effect ends if the caster speaks their own name aloud.
Knot of Stillness	[BIND]	Holds a single small object in place—a door, a latch, a coin on a table. The Weave does not lock; it suggests. A determined child could overcome it. A distracted guard will not notice.
Pale Light	[LIGHT]	Illuminates the caster's hand with a soft, steady glow. The light reaches Near range but dims before Far. Cannot be used to blind. Cannot be used to start fires. The Weave is specific.
Whisper	[MESSAGE]	Sends a sentence of up to eight words to a willing target within Near range. The target hears the words in the caster's voice, but no one else does. The Weave does not deliver lies. It delivers sounds.

2.1.2 On Failure, Minor

A cantrip's backlash is modest because the cantrip's ambition is modest. The Weave does not punish a stutter; it merely repeats the word incorrectly.

Ember Flick (Miss)	The spark jumps back. The caster's sleeve smoulders. Mark one Fatigue.
Hush (Partial)	The sound muffles but does not vanish. A witness tilts their head. The GM gains a Story Beat.
Warmth (Miss)	The Fatigue remains. The caster feels a phantom chill instead. The Weave has misread the prescription.
Folded Sight (Partial)	The caster's features blur, but a distinctive scar or piece of jewelry remains visible. The witness may recognize the detail later.

2.1.3 The First Spell I Learned

I was seventeen. My instructor, a woman whose name I have forgotten but whose patience I have not, placed a candle on a stone and told me to light it with my mind. I failed for three days. On the fourth day, I lit the candle. On the fifth day, I lit my sleeve.

The spell was [BURNING]. The tag was one. The difficulty was two. I rolled a miss and earned two boons, which I spent immediately to re-roll the die that had come up as a one. The second roll succeeded. The candle lit. The Weave did not applaud. My instructor nodded once and said, "Again."

That is the nature of cantrips. They are not impressive. They are foundations. Build them well, and the walls will follow. Build them poorly, and the walls will collapse. I have seen both.

2.1.4 When to Use a Cantrip

Use a cantrip when the cost of failure is manageable. A [LIGHT] that flickers is an inconvenience. A [GATE] that misfolds is a tragedy.

Use a cantrip when you are learning. The Weave is a patient teacher, but it expects homework.

Use a cantrip when you are tired. A cantrip's backlash will not kill you. It may embarrass you. It may singe your sleeve. It will not open a door to the Hollow.

Save the dangerous tags for when the candle is already burning.

2.1.5 A Final Observation

I have seen a master of Spellcraft light a candle with a glance. I have seen the same master extinguish a charging berserker's will with a whispered [FEAR]. Both are one-tag spells. Both rely on the same grammar. The difference is not in the tag. The difference is in the caster's understanding of when silence is a weapon.

Practice the small work. The large work will follow.

— *Lysandra*

3 The Defensive Arts

3.1 The Polite Art of Not Being Harmed

The young believe that the highest form of defense is a wall of flame. The middle-aged believe it is a well-placed parry. The old know that the highest form of defense is not being where the harm lands. The Weave agrees with the old.

These spells do not strike. They do not burn. They do not avenge. They simply *interpose*. A layer of still air between your ribs and the dagger. A whisper of misdirection that turns a sword's edge a finger's width from your throat. A ward that asks, politely, "*Would you mind terribly not?*"

The Weave is not a shield. It is a negotiation. These spells are the terms.

3.1.1 On the Nature of Defensive Magic

A defensive spell does not eliminate danger. It *repositions* it. A [WARD] does not make a door unbreakable; it makes the door inconvenient to break. A [DEFEND] does not make you invulnerable; it makes the attacker's blade hesitate at the moment of commitment.

The tags in this chapter are:

- [WARD] — A threshold effect. Something may not cross. The Weave enforces this as a suggestion, not a law, but the suggestion is strong.
- [DEFEND] — A personal barrier. The Weave thickens the air, hardens the skin, or simply distracts the eye. Harm becomes Fatigue. Steel becomes discomfort.
- [PROTECT] — An interposition. The Weave places the caster between a threat and a target. Dangerous. Often heroic. Usually foolish.
- [COUNTER] — A response. The Weave unravels another spell as it forms. Timing is everything. A moment too late, and you are swallowing fire.
- [REFLECT] — A reversal. The Weave catches an incoming effect and sends it back toward its source. The Weave does this reluctantly. It dislikes arguments.

3.1.2 Common Defensive Spells

Table 3.1: Defensive Spells of the Wary Caster

Spell	Tags	What It Does (in practice)
Still Air	[DEFEND]	A cushion of motionless air settles around the caster. The first physical attack against them within the next few heartbeats loses much of its force. A sword that would have opened a vein leaves a bruise. A bruise is survivable.
Warded Threshold	[WARD]	The caster touches a door, a window, or a bridge. For a short while, the Weave discourages crossing. A guard will find a reason to patrol elsewhere. A pursuer will hesitate. The effect is psychological, not physical. The Weave is polite.
Intercept	[PROTECT][NEAR]	When an ally within Near range is attacked, the caster may interpose themselves. The harm intended for the ally lands on the caster instead. The Weave permits this transfer but does not mitigate it. Use sparingly.
Unweave	[COUNTER]	The caster watches an enemy cast a spell and attempts to speak the counter-grammar before the Weave answers. On success, the enemy's spell dissipates harmlessly. On failure, both spells may misfire. The Weave dislikes being interrupted.
Shield of Reflection	[WARD][REFLECT]	A shimmering disc of barely- visible force hovers before the caster. The first projectile—arrow, bolt, thrown knife—that strikes the disc is turned back toward its source. The returned projectile is less accurate. The Weave does not aim.
Circle of Salt	[WARD][AREA]	The caster draws a line of salt, chalk, or ash in a circle around themselves and allies. For the duration of a scene, creatures of spirit—ghosts, wraiths, some fae—cannot cross the line. Mortals may step over with a shrug. The Weave distinguishes between kinds of hunger.
Phantom Parry	[DEFEND][STRIKE]	The Weave conjures a momentary replica of a blade the caster is holding. The replica intercepts one melee attack, then vanishes. The caster does not need to move. The Weave does the work. The caster must still breathe.

3.1.3 On Failure, Protective

Defensive spells that fail do not merely fail. They *invert*. The Weave's protection becomes a vulnerability.

Still Air (Miss)		The cushion of air becomes a vacuum. The caster's breath catches. Mark one Fatigue. The attack lands without mitigation.
Warded (Partial)	Threshold	The ward holds, but the Weave's suggestion is weak. A determined pursuer may overcome it with a moment's effort. The GM gains a Story Beat.
Intercept (Partial)		The caster interposes, but the transfer is incomplete. Both the caster and the ally take reduced harm. Neither is safe. Both are angry.
Unweave (Miss)		The counter-grammar fails. Worse, it amplifies. The enemy's spell resolves with greater force. The GM gains two Story Beats.
Phantom (Miss)	Parry	The replica blade appears, but it is oriented incorrectly. The caster's own defense is compromised. The next attack against them has Dominant Position.

3.1.4 A Lesson from the Arena

A student once asked me, “*Why would I cast a defensive spell when I could simply not be there?*”

She was correct. The best defense is absence. But you cannot always be absent. Sometimes you must stand where the harm is, because someone else cannot run.

I recall a graduate of the Class of Eight Hundred and Forty- Three—a woman named Calypso, now a captain in the Oshiiran lancers. She stood between a charging elephant and a fallen comrade. She had no time to move. She had time to cast [DEFEND][PROTECT].

She rolled a partial success. The Weave interposed. The elephant struck. She took the harm meant for the fallen soldier and walked with a limp for a month. The soldier survived. Calypso called it a fair trade.

The Weave does not promise fairness. It promises *exchange*.

3.1.5 When to Defend

Cast a defensive spell when the alternative is bleeding.

Cast it when you are protecting someone who cannot protect themselves.

Cast it when you have failed to be absent.

Do not cast it when you are safe. The Weave respects economy. A ward that is never tested is a lecture no one attended.

3.1.6 A Final Observation on Wards

The most effective ward I have ever cast was not a spell. It was a lie. I told a Chain- Lantern inquisitor that the room behind me was full of reliquary guards. He believed me. He walked away.

The Weave is a tool. Deception is another. Learn both.

— *Lysandra*

4 The Unseen Hand

4.1 The Unseen Hand

The eye is a lazy witness. Show it what it expects to see, and it will sleep through a revolution. The ear is even worse. I have watched a student walk past a lecturing Synod clerk while humming a lullaby; the clerk did not look up. He was waiting for the punchline.

These spells do not fight. They *nudge*. The Weave does not erase; it *suggests*. And the observer, poor creature, accepts the suggestion because it is easier than doubt.

4.1.1 On the Nature of Unseen Magic

A spell of the unseen hand does not make a thing invisible. It makes it *forgettable*. A guard who sees a veiled intruder will think “*delivery boy*” and return to his dice. A merchant who finds a ledger page blank will think “*clerk’s error*” and close the drawer. The Weave does not lie. It merely omits.

The tags in this chapter are:

- **[VEIL]** — The caster blurs a single target’s appearance. Not invisibility. *Plausible denial*.
- **[SILENCE]** — A zone or target becomes mute. The Weave does not steal sound; it *postpones* it.
- **[ILLUSION]** — The Weave paints a false image. It does not move unless the caster concentrates. It does not cast a shadow unless the caster remembers.
- **[SCRY]** — The Weave lends the caster a distant eye. A glimpse of a room, a face, a document. Never the whole truth.
- **[MEMORY]** — The Weave touches the past. A recollection may be blurred, sharpened, or—with care—removed. The Weave charges interest.

4.1.2 Common Spells of the Unseen Hand

Table 4.1: Spells of the Unseen Hand

Spell	Tags	What It Does (in practice)
Hush	[SILENCE]	A zone the size of a dining table becomes mute. Shouts become whispers. Whispers become nothing. The Weave does not care what you say; it only cares that no one hears it. Lasts a few heartbeats.
Folded Face	[VEIL]	Your features blur. Not invisible—merely <i>forgettable</i> . A guard will look at you and think “ <i>passing tradesman</i> .” A lover will feel a flicker of uncertainty. The effect ends if you speak your own name.
False Door	[VEIL][ILLUSION]	You paint an archway onto a stone wall. It looks real. It feels real to the touch, for a moment. It is not real. The Weave permits this deception, but it will remember that you lied. On a partial success, the door flickers when someone reaches for it.
The Unspoken Name	[SILENCE][TARGET]	You mute a single creature. They open their mouth. Nothing comes out. The Weave does not steal their voice; it merely <i>misplaces</i> it for a few heartbeats. The target will find their voice again—usually at the worst possible moment.
Crowd's Shroud	[VEIL][AREA]	You blur the entire party. To any observer more than Near away, you are indistinguishable from market-goers, cargo crates, or stray dogs. The Weave does not make you invisible; it makes you <i>boring</i> .
Distant Gaze	[SCRY]	You close your eyes and see a location you have visited before within a mile. The vision is grainy, like a reflection in rippled water. You cannot hear. You cannot act. Your body is helpless for the duration.
Gloss of the Forgotten	[MEMORY]	You touch a document, a ledger, or a letter. The Weave blurs a single word or number. The reader will see a smudge and assume the ink was wet. The Weave does not destroy evidence; it <i>delays</i> discovery.
Phantom Footstep	[ILLUSION][AREA]	You create the sound of footsteps moving away from you—down a corridor, up a stair, into a crowd. A pursuer will follow the sound. For a few heartbeats, they will be looking in the wrong direction.

4.1.3 On Failure, Unseen

A veiling that fails is not a failure of invisibility. It is a failure of *suggestion*. The witness sees what you tried to hide—and they know you tried to hide it.

Folded Face (Partial)	Your features blur, but a distinctive scar or piece of jewelry remains visible. The witness may recognize the detail later. The GM gains a Story Beat.
False Door (Miss)	The archway appears, but it is conspicuously false—a painting, not a passage. Anyone who sees it will know magic was attempted. The GM gains two Story Beats.
Crowd's Shroud (Partial)	Your party blurs, but your footsteps remain audible. A guard tilts their head. They are now watching the area, not the crowd.
Distant Gaze (Miss)	You see nothing. Worse, the Weave shows you a <i>wrong</i> image—a room you have never entered, a face you do not recognize. The GM may use this false vision as a complication later.
Gloss of the Forgotten (Miss)	The word you tried to blur becomes <i>emphasized</i> . A subtle glow surrounds it. The reader will notice immediately. The GM gains a Story Beat.

4.1.4 A Story from the Archivolt

I was once hired to retrieve a document from a counting-house in Silkstrand. The document was a promissory note; the client was a merchant who had been cheated. I could have stolen it. I chose to erase it instead.

I cast [MEMORY] on the ledger page. The Weave obliged. The number vanished, replaced by a faint smudge that looked like old ink. The clerk closed the ledger. The debt was forgotten.

The Weave remembered, though. A month later, I received a letter. The letter contained a single word: *“Interest.”* I have not opened a ledger since without leaving a pinch of salt on the spine.

4.1.5 When to Use the Unseen Hand

Use veiling when the truth would be inconvenient but a lie would be exhausting.

Use silence when the sound of your passage would be louder than your alibi.

Use illusion when you need a door that does not exist, or a guard who is not there.

Do not use memory lightly. The Weave is not a librarian. It does not stamp *“withdrawn.”* It stamps *“deferred.”* And the deferral always comes due.

4.1.6 A Final Observation on Witness

The unseen hand works best when there is a witness to deceive. A veiled face in an empty room is still a veiled face. A silenced argument between two people who are already alone is merely awkward.

But a veiled face in a crowd? A silenced footstep in a guarded hallway? The Weave thrives on witnesses. It uses their assumptions as fuel.

The best spell of the unseen hand is the one that convinces the witness that nothing happened at all.

— *Lysandra*

5 The Elemental Chorus

5.1 The Elemental Chorus

Fire, water, earth, air. The old tetrad. Every student learns them in the first week; every master learns to fear them in the first decade. The Weave does not favor one element over another. It favors *clarity*. A fire that knows its shape is safer than a breeze that does not know its direction.

These spells are the loud ones. They leave scorch marks, puddles, cracked stones, and ringing ears. The Synod notices loud spells. So do witnesses. Cast with appropriate discretion.

5.1.1 On the Nature of Elemental Magic

An elemental spell persuades the Weave to borrow a quality from the physical world. [BURNING] is not fire; it is the *idea* of fire, given temporary citizenship in reality. [WAVE] is not water; it is the *memory* of water, shaped by the caster's will.

The Weave is not a reservoir of elements. It is a grammar of *resonance*. You speak [STORM], and the Weave hums in sympathy with every lightning strike within a mile. You speak [STONE], and the Weave recalls the weight of a mountain it has never seen but can imagine.

The tags in this chapter are drawn from the eight elements recognized by the Thepyrgos curriculum. I list them here for reference, though the spells that follow will demonstrate their use.

- **Fire:** [BURNING], [STORM] (lightning), [FLARE]
- **Water:** [WAVE], [FLOOD], [MIST]
- **Earth:** [STONE], [ROOT], [DUST]
- **Air:** [WIND], [GUST], [THUNDER]
- **Fate:** [CHANCE], [OMEN], [KNOT]
- **Life:** [GROWTH], [BLOOM], [WITHER]
- **Luck:** [FORTUNE], [MISFORTUNE], [BALANCE]
- **Death:** [ASH], [REST], [SILENCE] (in its terminal form)

Some elements are safer than others. Fire is predictable. Fate is not. I advise students to master the tetrad before reaching toward the higher notes.

5.1.2 Common Elemental Spells

Table 5.1: Spells of the Elemental Chorus

Spell	Tags	What It Does (in practice)
Ember Dart	[BURNING][STRIKE]	A bolt of concentrated heat flies from the caster's hand toward a single target within Near range. It sears cloth, singes skin, and spoils uncovered food. Lethal? No. Distracting? Very.
Rising Mist	[WATER][AREA]	A thick, cool fog billows from a point the caster chooses, filling a Near zone within Near range. Vision beyond a few paces is impossible. The fog persists for a few heartbeats, then dissipates. The Weave does not appreciate stasis.
Stone Grip	[EARTH][BIND]	Stone or packed earth beneath a target's feet softens, then hardens. The target's ankles are held fast. A strong pull may break the bond. A wise target does not struggle.
Sudden Gale	[AIR][FORCE]	A blast of wind erupts from the caster's palm, pushing a single target one range band away from the caster. The target may keep their feet if they are expecting the shove. The Weave does not guarantee grace.
Storm Spark	[STORM][STRIKE]	A thin line of lightning jumps from the caster's finger to a metal object within Near range. The object becomes briefly hot. A creature holding the object marks one Fatigue. The crack of thunder is audible for a considerable distance.
Rippling Step	[WATER][LEAP]	The caster dissolves into a spray of droplets and reforms within Near range at a location they can see. Passing through grates or under doors is possible if the gap is not sealed. The Weave does not clean the caster's clothes.
Dust Veil	[EARTH][VEIL]	A cloud of fine dust rises around the caster, obscuring their exact position. Attacks against the caster suffer uncertainty. The dust settles quickly. The caster's cough is not magical.
Cinder Breath	[BURNING][AREA]	The caster exhales a cone of hot ash and cinders. Everyone in Close range before them must shield their eyes or suffer the distraction. The caster's throat will be sore for an hour.

Table 5.1 – continued

Spell	Tags	What It Does (in practice)
Tremor Tap	[EARTH][WAVE]	The caster strikes the ground with their foot or a staff. A ripple of motion travels through the earth, knocking creatures in a Close line off balance. The Weave amplifies the tap but does not aim.

5.1.3 On Failure, Elemental

Elemental failure is rarely subtle. The Weave does not misplace a syllable; it *overstates* the resonance.

Ember Dart (Miss)	The bolt flares wide, igniting a nearby object. A curtain, a stack of papers, a guard's sleeve. The GM gains a Story Beat and may tick a Fire Hazard timer.
Rising Mist (Partial)	The fog rises, but it also drifts toward the caster. Visibility for everyone is reduced, including allies. The caster's own breath fogs before their eyes.
Stone Grip (Miss)	The stone softens, but it does not harden again. The floor becomes unstable. Anyone stepping on that spot within the next few minutes may stumble. The GM gains a Story Beat.
Sudden Gale (Partial)	The wind pushes the target, but the caster is also pushed backward one step. The Weave has shared the momentum. Neither party is where they intended to be.
Storm Spark (Miss)	The lightning does not strike the intended target. It strikes the nearest metal object—which may be the caster's own belt buckle. Mark one Fatigue. The thunder is still loud.
Dust Veil (Partial)	The dust rises, but it also coats the caster's eyes and mouth. They cannot see clearly for a moment. Their next action suffers a penalty.

5.1.4 A Lesson from the Quadrangle

A student in my Elemental Theory seminar—a young man from the Vilikari marches, eager and careless—attempted [STORM][STRIKE] during a practical examination. The target was a bronze disc on a stand. The tags were two. The Difficulty was three.

He rolled a miss.

The lightning did not strike the disc. It struck the iron chandelier above the examination hall. The chandelier fell. No one was injured, but the noise attracted a Synod clerk, who wrote a report, which found its way to the Chain- Lanterns, who visited my classroom the following week.

The student passed the course. He did not pass the year. He transferred to a college that studied agricultural thaumaturgy, where he now grows larger potatoes with [GROWTH] and [BLOOM]. I am told he is content.

The Weave does not punish ambition. It merely *redirects* it.

5.1.5 When to Use the Elemental Chorus

Use fire when you need a distraction. Use water when you need to not be seen. Use earth when you need someone to stay where they are. Use air when you need someone to go somewhere else.

Use storm when you are prepared to be noticed.

Do not use the higher elements—Fate, Luck, Life, Death—unless you have mastered the tetrad. A mispronounced [BURNING] is a singed eyebrow. A mispronounced [FORTUNE] is a decade of bad luck. The Weave's interest rates are higher for abstract nouns.

5.1.6 A Final Observation on the Tetrad

The old masters taught that the four elements are the foundation of all magic. They were wrong. The foundation of all magic is *intention*. The elements are merely the vocabulary.

Still, a rich vocabulary is useful. You can intimidate a guard with a wall of fire. You cannot intimidate them with a well- intentioned pause.

Learn the elements. Then learn when to remain silent.

— *Lysandra*

6 The Dangerous Door

6.1 The Dangerous Door

The Synod calls them “unstable quanta.” The Chain-Lanterns call them “proscribed manifestations.” I call them *interesting*. A dangerous tag is not forbidden. It is merely expensive. The Weave adds a surcharge—not because it disapproves, but because folding reality requires more ink than lighting a candle.

These spells are the ones that rewrite the scene. A [LEAP] that bypasses a locked door. A [GATE] that connects two rooms that are not adjacent. A [TRANSFORM] that changes a guard into a frog. A [DOMINATE] that makes an enemy lay down their sword. The Weave permits these effects. It also *watches* them more closely.

I have cast dangerous spells. I have survived most of them. The ones I did not survive, I do not discuss.

6.1.1 On the Nature of Dangerous Tags

A dangerous tag adds a surcharge of two to the spell’s Difficulty instead of one. The Weave does not explain why. I have my theories. Reality has inertia; persuading it to fold, teleport, or alter its substance requires more energy than persuading it to warm your hands.

The tags in this chapter are:

- [LEAP] — The caster moves from one location to another without crossing the space between. Short range. Line of sight required. The Weave does not like being asked to ignore distance.
- [FOLD] — Similar to [LEAP], but the caster may bend space around an obstacle. A wall, a door, a guard’s line of sight. The Weave dislikes being asked to ignore geometry.
- [GATE] — A two- way portal between two locations. Range can be considerable. The Weave dislikes being asked to create permanent exceptions.
- [TRANSFORM] — The caster changes a target’s form. A person into a newt, a sword into a ribbon, a lock into a puddle of wax. The Weave dislikes being asked to forget what a thing is.
- [CREATE] — The caster manifests a mundane object from nothing. A key, a rope, a coin. The object lasts for a scene, then crumbles to dust. The Weave dislikes being asked to pay for purchases it did not approve.
- [SUMMON] — The caster calls a spirit, elemental, or minor Outsider into their presence. The creature is not compelled to obey. Negotiation follows. The Weave dislikes being asked to open doors that should remain closed.

- **[DOMINATE]** — The caster imposes their will on a sentient creature. The target resists. The Weave dislikes being asked to erase agency.
- **[REVIVE]** — The caster reverses time for a few heartbeats. An action is undone. A wound is unmade. The Weave *hates* being asked to contradict itself.

6.1.2 Common Dangerous Spells

Table 6.1: Spells of the Dangerous Door

Spell	Tags	What It Does (in practice)
Threshold Step	[LEAP]	The caster vanishes and reappears anywhere within Near range that they can see. A wall is still a wall. A closed door is still a door. The Weave does not give you eyes on the other side.
Fold the Wall	[FOLD][AREA]	The caster bends space around a single barrier—a wall, a hedge, a line of guards. They and anyone holding their hand step through to the other side. The Weave complains about the extra passengers.
Open the Way	[GATE]	The caster creates a shimmering portal between two locations they have visited. The portal lasts for three heartbeats. The Weave charges a toll in memory—a fact, a name, a recent conversation. You will not notice the loss until you need it.
New Skin	[TRANSFORM][SELF]	The caster alters their own appearance. Face, build, voice—all change. The new face is not a specific person's; it is a plausible stranger. The Weave does not forge documents.
Turn the Blade	[TRANSFORM][STRIKE]	The caster touches a weapon. The weapon becomes a harmless object—a flower, a ribbon, a dead fish. The effect lasts for a few heartbeats. The Weave's sense of humour is evident in the result.
Coin from Ash	[CREATE]	The caster clenches their fist and opens it to reveal a single silver coin. The coin is real for one scene, then crumbles. The Weave does not care about inflation.
Call the Wisp	[SUMMON]	The caster whistles a specific note. A minor spirit—a wisp, a shade, a house-brownie—appears within Near range. The spirit is not a servant. It may be bargained with. The Weave does not mediate.

Table 6.1 – continued

Spell	Tags	What It Does (in practice)
Speak My Will	[DOMINATE][TARGET]	The caster speaks a single imperative—“ <i>Stop.</i> ” “ <i>Kneel.</i> ” “ <i>Sleep.</i> ”—and the target must resist or obey. The Weave does not care about the morality of the command.
Breath Returned	[REVIVE][TOUCH]	The caster touches a creature that has died within the last few heartbeats. The Weave reverses time locally. The creature lives. Something else dies in their place. The Weave does not explain the accounting.

6.1.3 On Failure, Dangerous

A dangerous spell that fails is not a mishap. It is a *conversation* with a reality that is now paying attention.

Threshold (Miss)	Step	The caster vanishes and reappears in the same spot. The Weave has noted their destination and found it unacceptable. The caster marks one Fatigue. The GM gains two Story Beats.
Open the Way (Partial)		The portal opens, but it leads to a different location—similar, but wrong. The room is furnished differently. The person waiting is not an ally. The GM chooses the destination.
New Skin (Miss)		The caster’s appearance changes, but the change is unstable. Their face shifts every few heartbeats. Strangers are unsettled. Allies are confused. The effect lasts until the caster sleeps.
Turn the Blade (Partial)		The weapon transforms, but only halfway. A sword becomes a sword-shaped ribbon. It still cuts, but it also flaps in the breeze. The target may still use it, at a penalty.
Call the Wisp (Miss)		The spirit arrives. It is not the spirit the caster called. It is larger. It is hungrier. It is not hostile—yet. But it is <i>interested</i> . The GM gains three Story Beats.
Speak My Will (Partial)		The target resists the command, but the effort leaves them disoriented. They lose their next action. They also remember that someone tried to dominate them.
Breath Returned (Any outcome)		Something dies. If the spell succeeds, the Weave takes a life of equivalent weight—a bird, a rat, a child in a distant village. If the spell fails, the Weave takes the caster’s memory of the person they tried to save. The Weave does not refund exchanges.

6.1.4 The Lecture I Do Not Give Anymore

I used to teach a seminar on dangerous tags. I stopped after the incident with the gate.

A student—bright, impatient, from a family of minor nobility—attempted [GATE] during a supervised examination. He had performed the spell three times in practice. The fourth time, the Weave answered differently.

The portal opened. It did not lead to the adjacent hallway. It led to a room I have never seen, filled with mirrors facing each other. In the infinite reflections, the student saw versions of himself that had made different choices. One was a murderer. One was a saint. One was a corpse.

He closed the portal. He sat down. He did not speak for three days. When he finally spoke, he asked to withdraw from the University. He is now a sheep farmer in Acasia. He writes me once a year. His letters do not mention magic.

The Weave is not a toy. It is a language. Dangerous tags are the profanity. Use them when you must. Use them when the alternative is worse. Do not use them to impress your peers.

6.1.5 When to Use Dangerous Tags

Use [LEAP] when the door is locked and the guard is turning.

Use [GATE] when you are fleeing and the road behind you is on fire.

Use [TRANSFORM] when the enemy's weapon is the only thing keeping you from the exit.

Use [DOMINATE] when a friend is about to make a lethal mistake and will not listen to reason.

Do not use [REVIVE]. The Weave's accounting is cruel. I have seen it. I will not describe it.

6.1.6 A Final Observation on the Door

Every dangerous spell opens a door. Some doors close when you walk through them. Some doors stay open, waiting for something to follow. The Weave does not close doors it did not open. That is your responsibility.

Cast with intention. Cast with necessity. Cast with a plan for what comes back with you.

— *Lysandra*

7 The Weave's Receipt

7.1 The Weave's Receipt

Every spell is a transaction. The Weave provides the effect; the caster provides the intention. But the Weave also issues a receipt—a record of the transaction's friction. We call it *backlash*.

Students fear backlash. They imagine it as punishment, a lash, a scar. It is none of these things. Backlash is *color*. A spark that did not exist before. A chill that passes through the room. A witness who shivers and does not know why. The Weave does not punish. It *remarks*.

I have seen a student weep at a minor backlash. I have seen another shrug off a catastrophic failure and ask for more chalk. The difference is not in the Weave. It is in the caster's relationship with imperfection.

7.1.1 On the Nature of Backlash

Backlash occurs when the Weave is asked to do something it found *interesting*. A clean success with no ones produces no backlash because the Weave had no comment. A success with ones produces minor backlash—a comment, a footnote, a raised eyebrow. A partial success produces moderate backlash—a paragraph of unsolicited advice. A miss produces major or catastrophic backlash—a full critique, delivered in the language of consequence.

The severity of backlash is also influenced by the caster's Position when they cast. A Dominant casting—controlled, prepared, witnessed—insulates the caster from the worst of the Weave's commentary. A Desperate casting—rushed, frightened, improvisational—invites the Weave to speak more freely.

I have cast in Dominant Position many times. The Weave was polite. I have cast in Desperate Position twice. The Weave was *memorable*.

7.1.2 The Spectrum of Receipts

Table 7.1: Backlash Severity and Its Meaning

Severity	What the Weave says	What it feels like
Minor	<i>"Noted."</i>	A spark, a chill, a whisper. A single point of Fatigue. A distraction that costs a die. The Weave is acknowledging the transaction.

Table 7.1 – continued

Severity	What the Weave says	What it feels like
Moderate	<i>“Explain yourself.”</i>	The spell works, but the Weave adds a condition—Blinded, Silenced, Entangled. A ward collapses. An alarm sounds. The Weave is asking for better grammar.
Major	<i>“We need to talk.”</i>	Harm. A permanent scar. An unwanted transformation. The spell inverts—healing becomes harm, a veil becomes a beacon. The Weave is correcting the record.
Catastrophic	<i>“I will remember this.”</i>	A reality fracture. A Patron manifests. A threshold opens where none should exist. The caster's name is added to a ledger that never closes. The Weave is taking a personal interest.

7.1.3 Backlash by Element

The flavor of backlash depends on the element of the spell. A [BURNING] spell that backfires produces smoke and sparks. A [WAVE] spell produces a slick floor and damp clothes. The Weave is consistent in its inconsistency.

Table 7.2: Elemental Backlash Examples

Element	Minor (1–2 SB)	Moderate (3–4 SB)
Fire	Smoke, sparks, a singed sleeve	An uncontrolled flame ignites nearby objects
Water	A damp floor, a splash, soggy papers	A small flood pools around the caster's feet
Earth	A tremor, dust in the eyes, a cracked flagstone	A binding root grips the caster's ankle
Air	A sudden gust, a deafening ring, scattered papers	A strong wind pushes the caster off balance
Fate	A door closes unexpectedly, a coin lands on edge	A prophecy—the Weave speaks a future that may be avoided
Life	A patch of grass grows through the floor, a nosebleed	A fever—the caster shivers and sweats for an hour
Luck	A small object falls from a shelf	A friend suffers a minor misfortune nearby
Death	A chill, a whisper of a forgotten name	A ghostly presence watches for a scene

7.1.4 A Lesson in Humility

I was examining a student in her third year. She was talented—perhaps the most talented I had taught in a decade. She attempted a [GATE] during a practical examination, in Desperate Position, because she had miscalculated the time and the examination hall was about to close.

She rolled a miss.

The portal opened. It did not lead to the exit. It led to a basement storage room filled with old examination papers. The papers flew out like startled birds. The Weave added a commentary: every paper that landed on the floor had a failing grade marked in red ink that was not there before.

The student was not harmed. She was, however, required to reshelve the entire archive. She passed the examination the following year. She never cast [GATE] in Desperate Position again.

The Weave's receipt is not a punishment. It is a *reminder* of what you owe to preparation.

7.1.5 When Backlash is a Gift

I have learned to welcome minor backlash. A spark that lights a candle you needed lit. A chill that alerts you to a spirit in the room. A whisper that contains a word you were missing.

The Weave is not your enemy. It is your conversation partner. Sometimes it interrupts. Sometimes the interruption is the point.

A student once cast [SCRY] to locate a stolen artifact. She rolled a partial success and earned a minor backlash. The Weave showed her not the artifact's location, but a reflection of the thief's face in a puddle. She did not find the artifact that day. She found the thief. The artifact followed.

She thanked the Weave. I have never seen a student thank the Weave before. The Weave did not respond. It rarely does. But the next spell she cast was a clean success.

Coincidence? Perhaps. Perhaps not.

7.1.6 A Final Observation on Receipts

Keep a record of your backlashes. I do. I have a ledger labeled "*Interest Paid.*" It contains a thousand entries: "*Burnt sleeve, 862 AR.*" "*Frog in throat, 864 AR.*" "*Portal to the wrong basement, 867 AR.*"

The Weave does not charge interest. It charges *attention*. A caster who ignores backlash is a caster who will eventually owe more than they can pay. A caster who studies backlash is a caster who learns the Weave's sense of humour.

And the Weave, I have learned, has an excellent sense of humour. It is merely very, very dry.

— *Lysandra*

8 On Practice

9 On Practice

Theory is a map. Practice is the road. I have known students who memorised every tag, every elemental resonance, every historical footnote on the Weave's temperament. They could lecture for hours. They could not light a candle without singeing their own sleeve.

This chapter is for those who wish to walk the road, not merely admire the cartography.

9.1 The Shape of Learning

You will fail. Accept this now. The Weave is not impressed by your pedigree, your patron, or your previous successes. It will treat your first spell the same as your thousandth: with polite attention and a receipt.

The difference between a novice and a master is not the absence of failure. It is the speed of recovery.

9.1.1 The Three Questions, Restated

Before every casting, ask yourself three questions. I have written them on the wall of my classroom. I have written them on the inside of my own eyelids.

1. **What do I intend?** Be precise. *"I want to hurt him"* is not precise. *"I want to sear his sword hand so he drops the blade"* is precise. The Weave rewards specificity.
2. **Which tags serve this intent?** Name them aloud. *"[BURNING]. [STRIKE]. That is two tags. DV three."* Speaking the tags is not a ritual. It is a discipline.
3. **What is the risk?** Look at your Position. Look at your Fatigue. Look at the witnesses. If the answer is *"I could die,"* consider not casting. Consider running.

A student who answers these questions honestly will still fail. But they will fail *with intention*. And intentional failure is the mother of accidental mastery.

9.2 The Practice Regimen

I recommend the following schedule for novice casters. It is not gentle. It is not accelerated. It is *consistent*.

9.2.1 Week One: Cantrips Only

Cast [LIGHT] until your hand glows in your sleep. Cast [HEAL] on paper cuts. Cast [SILENCE] on your own footsteps. Do not attempt a two- tag spell until you have not singed your sleeve for three consecutive days.

9.2.2 Week Two: The Defensive Arts

Stand in a safe space. Have a friend throw soft objects at you. Cast [DEFEND]. Learn what it feels like to interpose the Weave between yourself and a threat. The friend should throw harder as you improve.

9.2.3 Week Three: The Unseen Hand

Practice [VEIL] in a mirror. Watch your features blur. Say your own name aloud and watch them snap back. Learn the difference between hiding from the world and hiding from yourself.

9.2.4 Week Four: The Elemental Chorus

Find a patch of bare earth. Cast [BURNING] on a dry leaf. Cast [WAVE] on a puddle. Cast [STONE] on a pebble. Cast [WIND] on a feather. Do not move to the next element until the previous one has stopped surprising you.

9.2.5 Week Five and Beyond

You are now ready to fail at more interesting spells. Attempt a [GATE] between two rooms you know well. Attempt a [LEAP] across a gap you could jump without magic. Attempt a [TRANSFORM] on a piece of fruit. The fruit will not thank you.

9.3 On Failure, Revisited

I have failed more spells than most students will ever cast. I keep a list. It is long. It is also instructional.

9.3.1 What Failure Teaches

- A miss teaches you that the Weave has opinions. Listen to them.
- A partial teaches you that the Weave is willing to negotiate. Learn its terms.
- A catastrophic failure teaches you that the Weave has a sense of humour. Do not make it laugh at your expense.

The worst failure is not the one that burns your sleeve. It is the one you do not learn from. I have seen students repeat the same mistake for years. They are not practicing. They are rehearsing.

9.3.2 The Ritual of the Burnt Sleeve

When I singe my sleeve—and I still do, occasionally—I cut off the burnt fabric and sew it into a book. That book is now the size of a small pillow. I call it my *Curriculum Vitae*.

You do not need to keep a book of burnt sleeves. But you should keep a record of your failures. Write down what you intended. Write down what you cast. Write down what the Weave said in reply. Read the list before every significant working. It will humble you. Humility is not the enemy of power. It is the container.

9.4 The Social Practice

Magic is not performed in a vacuum. It is performed in the presence of witnesses—allies, enemies, bystanders, and the Weave itself. Your reputation as a caster is not determined by your success rate. It is determined by how you handle your failures.

9.4.1 Casting in Company

When you cast in front of allies, narrate your intention. *“I am veiling our escape. If I fail, we run. Do not wait for me.”* This is not weakness. It is *contract*. The Weave respects contracts.

When you cast in front of enemies, narrate nothing. They do not deserve your grammar.

When you cast in front of bystanders, apologize in advance. *“This may be loud. I am sorry about your windows.”* The Weave appreciates courtesy. So do juries.

9.4.2 The Etiquette of Backlash

When your spell backfires and harms an ally, apologize. Then spend a Boon to help them. The Weave notices reciprocity.

When your spell backfires and harms an enemy, do not apologize. The Weave is not offended by efficiency.

When your spell backfires and harms a bystander, offer compensation. The Weave does not care about silver, but the bystander's lawyer does.

9.5 When to Walk Away

Not every problem requires a magical solution. I have seen students cast [LEAP] to cross a puddle. I have seen others cast [GATE] to avoid a conversation. These are not spells. They are *avoidance*.

9.5.1 The Non-Magical Alternative

Consider, before you cast:

- Can you walk around the obstacle?
- Can you talk to the guard?
- Can you wait for the situation to change?
- Can you simply *not*?

The Weave is patient. It will wait for you to need it. It does not need you to need it now.

9.5.2 The Decision to Stop

I have stopped casting three times in my life. The first was after a catastrophic failure that killed a horse. The second was after a partial success that blinded me for a day. The third was after a clean success that worked exactly as intended—and I realized I had solved the wrong problem.

Each time, I put down my focus. I walked away. I returned when I remembered why I had started.

You are not a bad caster if you take a break. You are a bad caster if you keep casting when you have forgotten your intention.

9.6 The Graduation Test

At the end of my course, I give students a single spell to cast. They do not know the spell in advance. They do not know the tags. They must construct it in the moment.

The scenario is always the same: a locked door, a burning room, and a single innocent who cannot escape.

The student must choose:

LEAP to reach the innocent.

BURNING to clear the debris.

WARD to protect them from the flames.

GATE to open an exit.

- Or something else entirely. I have seen [TRANSFORM] turn a door into mist. I have seen [SILENCE] confuse the fire itself. I have seen a student simply open the door—it was not locked—and lead the innocent out.

That student passed with highest honors.

9.7 A Final Word

Practice is not repetition. It is *attention*. A student who casts [LIGHT] a thousand times without thinking has learned nothing. A student who casts [LIGHT] ten times, each time noticing the flicker, the color, the Weave's momentary hesitation, has learned more than the thousand- cast student will ever know.

Pay attention. Keep notes. Singe your sleeves. Sew them into a book. One day, that book will be the size of a pillow, and you will look at it and know exactly how much you owe.

The Weave does not forget. Neither should you.

— *Lysandra*

A Talents of the Threadweaver

B Talents of the Threadweaver

B.1 Old Talents (From the Core)

These talents appear in the core rules. I list them here for completeness, with commentary in my own voice. A talent is not a spell. It is a habit the Weave has learned to expect from you.

B.1.1 Spellcraft (6 XP)

The foundational talent. Without it, you cannot shape the raw Weave. With it, you are a free caster—unlicensed, unbound, and unforgettable. The Synod disapproves. The Weave does not.

B.1.2 Ritual Mastery (6 XP)

You have learned to compress time. A spell that would require a full minute of focus now requires half that. The Weave is not impatient; it is merely willing to negotiate.

B.1.3 Elemental Focus (4 XP)

Choose an element—Fire, Water, Earth, Air, Fate, Life, Luck, Death. When you cast a spell of that element, the Weave listens more attentively. You gain an additional die on the roll. I recommend Fire. It is honest.

B.1.4 Stabilize Weave (8 XP)

Once per session, you may cancel a single Story Beat generated by your own casting. The Weave does not forget; it merely postpones the receipt. Use this when the consequences would be catastrophic. Use it sparingly otherwise.

B.1.5 Controlled Burn (4 XP)

Prerequisite: Spellcraft

When you roll a 1 on a Free Casting roll, you gain 1 Boon (maximum 1 Boon per roll from this talent). The GM still gains the Story Beat as normal. The Weave accepts this trade because you have learned to turn instability into momentum—but the Weave still collects its due.

B.1.6 Weave Resilience (4 XP)

When you suffer Backlash from a free casting roll, reduce its severity by one step. Catastrophic becomes Major. Major becomes Moderate. Moderate becomes Minor. Minor becomes nothing. The Weave respects those who can take a hit and keep casting.

B.1.7 Elemental Attunement (5 XP)

Requires Elemental Focus. When you cast a spell using your chosen element, you may reroll one failed die (not a one) once per casting. Additionally, you gain a bonus die to Arcana rolls when identifying or analyzing that element. The Weave appreciates specialists.

B.1.8 Backlash Siphon (6 XP)

Requires Spirit 3+. When you would suffer Backlash from a free casting roll, you may instead mark one Obligation to a Patron of your choice (or gain one Corruption if you have no Patron). The Backlash is negated. The Patron's attention is drawn. The Weave does not care who pays, only that someone does.

B.2 New Talents

These talents are not found in the core rules. They emerged from my own practice and the practice of my more interesting students.

B.2.1 Threadweaver's Patience (3 XP)

You may delay the resolution of a spell for up to one exchange. During the delay, you maintain the tags in your mind but do not release them. The Weave holds its breath. If you are interrupted during the delay, the spell fails and you suffer Backlash as if you had rolled a miss. Useful for ambushes. Dangerous for the impatient.

B.2.2 Signature Spell (5 XP)

Choose a single spell you have cast successfully at least three times. When you cast that spell, you gain +1 die on the roll. Additionally, the first time you cast it in a scene, you may ignore the first Story Beat generated by ones (if any). The Weave recognizes repetition. It does not applaud, but it does not interrupt.

B.2.3 Echo Recall (4 XP)

Once per session, after a failed casting, you may immediately attempt the same spell again with a +1 die. The Weave permits a second draft. The Backlash for the second attempt is applied regardless of success or failure. I have used this talent twice. Both times, the second draft was worse than the first. Your experience may differ.

B.2.4 Elemental Rebuke (6 XP)

Requires Elemental Focus. When an enemy casts a spell of your chosen element within Near range, you may attempt to twist the Weave against them. Roll a contested Arcana check. On success, the enemy's spell resolves as you choose—redirected, weakened, or reflected. On failure, you suffer the Backlash instead. The Weave does not appreciate interference, but it respects audacity.

B.2.5 Safe Harbour (4 XP)

When you cast a [WARD] or [DEFEND] spell, you may extend its protection to one adjacent ally without increasing the DV. The Weave does not distinguish between your skin and theirs, provided you ask politely.

B.2.6 Practiced Caster (2 XP)

Reduce the DV of any cantrip (one-tag spell) by 1, to a minimum of 1. A candle that lights itself is not a miracle. It is practice.

B.2.7 Catastrophe Insurance (8 XP)

Once per campaign, when you would suffer a Catastrophic Backlash, you may instead convert it to a Major Backlash. The Weave accepts this substitution because you have paid in advance—with a memory, a name, or a promise. I have not used this talent. I keep it in my ledger in case.

B.3 Talent Synergies

Some talents work well together. A few work against each other. The Weave does not police your combinations, but it will charge interest on contradictions.

B.3.1 The Stable Caster

Practiced Caster + Weave Resilience + Signature Spell (a reliable cantrip). You cast cantrips with trivial difficulty. You shrug off minor Backlashes. Your signature spell almost never goes wrong. You are not a spectacular caster. You are a *reliable* one. The Weave appreciates reliability.

B.3.2 The Elemental Specialist

Elemental Focus + Elemental Attunement + Elemental Rebuke. You have chosen an element and made it your own. Spells of that element are easier, more powerful, and occasionally turned back against your enemies. The Weave respects specialists. It also watches them more closely.

B.3.3 The Desperate Gambler

Backlash Siphon + Threadweaver's Patience + Catastrophe Insurance. You cast dangerous spells with dangerous tags. You defer the cost to patrons, to memories, to the future. You delay resolution to achieve perfect timing. And when catastrophe looms, you have a final escape. This combination is not recommended. It is also very effective.

B.3.4 The Silent Weaver

Safe Harbour + Signature Spell (a veiling or silencing spell) + Echo Recall. You are not a combat caster. You are a shadow. Your spells protect allies, hide movements, and erase evidence. When a veiling fails, you try again. The Weave does not notice you. That is the point.

B.4 A Final Observation on Talents

A talent is not a spell. It is a *tendency*. The Weave notices tendencies. Over time, the Weave adjusts its expectations. A caster who always uses Controlled Burn will find that the Weave offers fewer ones to convert. A caster who never uses Backlash Siphon will find that the Weave offers more.

The Weave is not a machine. It is a conversation partner. It learns your habits. It adjusts its replies. A talent is the grammar of that adjustment.

Choose your talents as you choose your words: with intention, with economy, and with an ear for how the Weave will answer.

— *Lysandra*

C Builds for the Threadweaver

D Builds for the Threadweaver

Theory is necessary. Practice is essential. But a map of the road is not the same as a traveling companion. The following builds are not prescriptions. They are *examples*—casters I have taught, fought alongside, or (in one case) fled from. Their choices reflect their circumstances. Yours will reflect yours.

I have organized these builds by Tier, from novice to master. Each build includes recommended Attributes, Skills, Talents, and signature spells. I have also added a note on playstyle—because the Weave responds to how you think, not only to what you cast.

D.1 Tier I: The Cautious Flame (30–40 XP)

D.1.1 Concept

You have learned enough to be dangerous—to yourself. You cast cantrips reliably. Two- tag spells make you nervous. Dangerous tags are a rumor you have heard from older students. You carry a focus (a stone, a coin, a dried flower) because it helps you remember your intention.

D.1.2 Attributes

- **Wits 3** (for perception and precision)
- **Spirit 2** (for will and resilience)
- **Body 1** (you are not a warrior)
- **Presence 1** (you are not a diplomat)

D.1.3 Skills

- **Arcana 2** (your core)
- **Lore 1** (you have read some theory)
- **Insight 1** (you watch witnesses)

D.1.4 Talents

- **Spellcraft** (6 XP) – mandatory
- **Practiced Caster** (2 XP) – cantrips cost almost nothing
- **Threadweaver’s Patience** (3 XP) – you learn to wait for the right moment

D.1.5 Signature Spells

- **Ember Flick** ([BURNING][STRIKE], DV 3) – your only offensive option
- **Warmth** ([HEAL], DV 2) – for Fatigue and minor injuries
- **Hush** ([SILENCE], DV 2) – for escaping notice

D.1.6 Playstyle

You stay at the back. You cast one spell per scene, then assess. You do not cast dangerous tags. You save your Boons for re-rolling ones, because a miss at Tier I is a lesson you can afford. Your allies protect you. You protect them from minor inconveniences.

D.1.7 Lysandra's Note

This was my build at thirty XP. I was not impressive. I was *alive*. The Weave respects survival.

D.2 Tier II: The Reliable Hand (41–90 XP)

D.2.1 Concept

You have survived. You know which tags work together and which produce interesting failures. You can cast two- tag spells without sweating. Dangerous tags are no longer rumors; you have used [LEAP] once, and you still have the scar.

D.2.2 Attributes

- **Wits 3** (unchanged; precision matters more than power)
- **Spirit 3** (you have learned to endure backlash)
- **Body 1**
- **Presence 2** (you have started to notice witnesses)

D.2.3 Skills

- **Arcana 3** (your core, now reliable)
- **Lore 2** (you have read the forbidden chapters)
- **Insight 1**
- **Stealth 1** (sometimes not casting is the best spell)

D.2.4 Talents

- **Spellcraft** (already taken)
- **Controlled Burn** (4 XP) – convert ones to Boons
- **Weave Resilience** (4 XP) – reduce backlash severity
- **Elemental Focus (Fire)** (4 XP) – you have chosen an element

D.2.5 Signature Spells

- **Ember Dart** ([BURNING][STRIKE], DV 3) – now with +1 die from Elemental Focus
- **Rising Mist** ([WATER][AREA], DV 3) – concealment and confusion
- **Threshold Step** ([LEAP], DV 4) – your first dangerous tag
- **Still Air** ([DEFEND], DV 2) – for when the enemy gets close

D.2.6 Playstyle

You are a generalist. You can hurt, hide, and run. You do not specialize. You keep one Boon in reserve for a re-roll, because you have learned that the Weave's sense of humour is not always kind. You cast dangerous tags only when the alternative is death.

D.2.7 Lysandra's Note

This was my build at sixty XP. I passed my examination. I also set fire to a desk. The Weave accepted the offering.

D.3 Tier III: The Specialist (91–150 XP)

D.3.1 Concept

You have chosen a path. You do not cast every element; you cast *your* element. Fire, or water, or shadow—you have learned its grammar, its moods, its favorite receipts. Dangerous tags are tools, not fears. You carry a ledger of your failures. It is thicker than your spellbook.

D.3.2 Attributes

- **Wits 4** (precision honed)
- **Spirit 4** (backlash is a conversation, not a wound)
- **Body 2** (you have learned to dodge)
- **Presence 2** (witnesses matter)

D.3.3 Skills

- **Arcana 4** (your core, now formidable)
- **Lore 3** (you have written marginalia in forbidden texts)
- **Insight 2**
- **Stealth 2**
- **Performance 1** (for veiling in crowds)

D.3.4 Talents (Fire Specialist)

- **Spellcraft**
- **Controlled Burn**
- **Weave Resilience**
- **Elemental Focus (Fire)**
- **Elemental Attunement (Fire)** (5 XP)
- **Elemental Rebuke (Fire)** (6 XP)
- **Signature Spell (Ember Dart)** (5 XP)

D.3.5 Signature Spells

- **Ember Dart** ([BURNING][STRIKE], DV 3) – now with +2 dice from Focus and Attunement, plus a reroll on failures
- **Cinder Breath** ([BURNING][AREA], DV 3) – crowd control
- **Storm Spark** ([STORM][STRIKE], DV 3) – for when fire is not enough
- **Fold the Wall** ([FOLD][AREA], DV 5) – dangerous, but you have practised
- **Breath Returned** ([REWIND][TOUCH], DV 5) – you have used this once. You will not speak of it.

D.3.6 Playstyle

You are a specialist. You know exactly what your element can do and exactly what it cannot. You do not waste spells on problems that a knife could solve. You reserve dangerous tags for the moments that define campaigns. Your allies trust you. They should.

D.3.7 Lysandra's Note

I have met three fire specialists at Tier III. Two are still alive. One is a crater. The Weave does not discriminate; it merely records.

D.4 Tier IV–V: The Walking Receipt (151+ XP)

D.4.1 Concept

You no longer fear backlash. You have learned to read the Weave's mood before you cast. You can feel when a dangerous tag will succeed and when it will merely be *interesting*. You carry no focus; you *are* the focus. Students whisper your name. The Synod has a file. The Weave has a receipt with your signature.

D.4.2 Attributes

- **Wits 5** (you see the Weave's grammar)
- **Spirit 5** (you have argued with backlash and won)
- **Body 3** (you have learned to survive your own failures)
- **Presence 4** (witnesses remember you)

D.4.3 Skills

- **Arcana 5** (your core is instinct)
- **Lore 4** (you have written books others fear to read)
- **Insight 3**
- **Stealth 3**
- **Performance 2**
- **Command 2** (for when witnesses need convincing)

D.4.4 Talents

- All previous, plus:
- **Catastrophe Insurance** (8 XP) – for the day you push too far
- **Echo Recall** (4 XP) – because sometimes the second draft works
- **Safe Harbour** (4 XP) – because you are not alone

D.4.5 Signature Spells

You no longer keep a fixed list. You improvise. You cast [GATE] to escape collapsing buildings. You cast [TRANSFORM] to turn an enemy's armour into silk. You cast [REWIND] when a friend falls, and you pay the Weave's price without flinching.

D.4.6 Playstyle

You are a legend. You do not cast spells; you *resolve* situations. The Weave listens when you speak because you have paid your receipts for decades. You are still capable of catastrophic failure. You simply survive it better than most.

D.4.7 Lysandra's Note

I am not Tier V. I have met three Tier V casters in my life. One is dead. One is missing. One is me, on a good day, when the Weave is feeling generous. The rest is practice.

D.5 A Final Comparison

	Tier I	Tier III	Tier V
Cantrips	Nervous	Confident	Instinctive
Two- Tag Spells	Risky	Routine	Boring
Dangerous Tags	Never	Sometimes	When appropriate
Backlash	Feared	Managed	Welcomed
Boons	Hoarded	Spent	Invested
Witnesses	Avoided	Noticed	Commanded

The Weave does not care which tier you occupy. It cares about your intention, your grammar, and your willingness to accept the receipt.

Build your caster. Cast your spells. Fail interestingly. Learn.

Then cast again.

— *Lysandra*

E Tags of the Weave

F Tags of the Weave

This appendix presents the complete tag vocabulary in two forms. The first table groups tags by Difficulty Value—standard tags (DV +1) and dangerous tags (DV +2). The second table lists all tags alphabetically with their families and a brief description.

Dangerous tags are marked in **red**. The Weave charges a surcharge for these tags not because it disapproves, but because folding reality requires more ink.

F.1 Tags by Difficulty Value

F.1.1 Standard Tags (DV +1)

These tags add one to the spell's Difficulty. They are the everyday vocabulary of the Weave—common, reliable, and (mostly) safe.

Table F.1: Standard Tags (DV +1)

Tag	Family	What It Does
AREA	Kinetic	Expands a spell's effect to cover a zone.
BEAST	Life	Communicates with or influences an animal.
BIND	Kinetic	Restrains a target.
BLESS	Affliction	Grants a favourable tag—luck, favor, or ward- key.
BURNING	Elemental (Fire)	Ignites, heats, or smokes a target.
COMMAND	Mind	Compels a single short action.
COUNTER	Reaction	Interrupts a casting or ritual in its window.
CURSE	Affliction	Attaches a hostile tag or timer to a target.
DEFEND	Force	Creates a personal barrier.
DISPEL	Kinetic	Unravels an ongoing magical effect.
FEAR	Mind	Instils dread in a target.
FORCE	Kinetic	Pushes, pulls, or strikes with invisible pressure.
FREEZING	Elemental (Water)	Cools, chills, or encases in frost.
HEAL	Life	Restores Fatigue or mends minor wounds.
LIGHT	Utility	Creates illumination.
MEMORY	Mind	Touches the past—blurring, sharpening, or removing recollections.
PROTECT	Utility	Reduces or deflects next harm.
PURIFY	Life	Removes poison, disease, or corruption.

Table F.1 – continued

Tag	Family	What It Does
REVEAL	Utility	Unveils hidden, glamoured, or invisible things.
SCRY	Mind	Reveals a distant location or object.
SENSE	Utility	Detects the presence of a named tag or element.
SHADOW	Utility	Deepens darkness, hides edges, obscures.
SILENCE	Utility	Suppresses sound in a zone or on a target.
STONE	Elemental (Earth)	Hardens, weights, or shapes stone and earth.
STORM	Elemental (Air)	Calls lightning, thunder, or static charge.
STRENGTHEN	Life	Temporarily enhances a body.
STRIKE	Kinetic	Focuses a spell on a single target.
VEIL	Mind	Conceals a target from sight, memory, or attention.
WAKEN	Life	Rouses a sleeping or stunned creature.
WALL	Kinetic	Creates a barrier of force, element, or illusion.
WAVE	Elemental (Water)	Moves water or creates pressure.
WIND	Elemental (Air)	Moves air.

F.1.2 Dangerous Tags (DV +2)

Table F.2: Dangerous Tags (DV +2)

Tag	Family	What It Does
ANIMATE	Creation	Gives motion to an inanimate object.
CREATE	Creation	Manifests a mundane object from nothing.
DOMINATE	Mind	Imposes the caster's will on a sentient creature.
FOLD	Space	Bends space around an obstacle.
GATE	Space	Creates a two- way portal between two locations.
GRAVITY	Space	Alters local gravity.
LEAP	Space	Teleports the caster within Near range.
REFLECT	Reaction	Turns the next targeted effect back on its source.
REWIND	Time	Reverses a few heartbeats.
STORE	Utility	Banks successes in a vessel for later use.
SUMMON	Creation	Calls a spirit, elemental, or minor Outsider.
TRANSMUTE	Creation	Changes one substance into another.
TRANSFORM	Creation	Changes a creature's form.

F.2 Tags Alphabetically

For quick reference at the table.

Table F.3: Tags Alphabetical

Tag	Family	DV Mod	Effect
ANIMATE	Creation	+2	Gives motion to an inanimate object.
AREA	Kinetic	+1	Expands effect to a zone.
BEAST	Life	+1	Communicates with or influences animals.
BIND	Kinetic	+1	Restrains a target.
BLESS	Affliction	+1	Grants a favourable tag.
BURNING	Elemental	+1	Ignites, heats, or smokes.
COMMAND	Mind	+1	Compels a single short action.
COUNTER	Reaction	+1	Interrupts a casting or ritual.
CREATE	Creation	+2	Manifests a mundane object from nothing.
CURSE	Affliction	+1	Attaches a hostile tag or timer.
DEFEND	Force	+1	Creates a personal barrier.
DISPEL	Kinetic	+1	Unravels an ongoing magical effect.
DOMINATE	Mind	+2	Imposes will on a sentient creature.
FEAR	Mind	+1	Instils dread.
FOLD	Space	+2	Bends space around an obstacle.
FORCE	Kinetic	+1	Pushes, pulls, or strikes with pressure.
FREEZING	Elemental	+1	Cools, chills, or encases in frost.
GATE	Space	+2	Creates a two- way portal.
GRAVITY	Space	+2	Alters local gravity.
HEAL	Life	+1	Restores Fatigue, mends minor wounds.
LEAP	Space	+2	Teleports the caster within Near range.
LIGHT	Utility	+1	Creates illumination.
MEMORY	Mind	+1	Touches the past—blurs, sharpens, removes.
PROTECT	Utility	+1	Reduces or deflects next harm.
PURIFY	Life	+1	Removes poison, disease, corruption.
REFLECT	Reaction	+2	Turns next targeted effect back on source.
REVEAL	Utility	+1	Unveils hidden, glamoured, or invisible things.
REWIND	Time	+2	Reverses a few heartbeats.
SCRY	Mind	+1	Reveals a distant location or object.
SENSE	Utility	+1	Detects presence of a named tag or element.
SHADOW	Utility	+1	Deepens darkness, hides edges.
SILENCE	Utility	+1	Suppresses sound.
STONE	Elemental	+1	Hardens, weights, or shapes stone and earth.
STORE	Utility	+2	Banks successes in a vessel for later use.
STORM	Elemental	+1	Calls lightning, thunder, static charge.
STRENGTHEN	Life	+1	Temporarily enhances body.
STRIKE	Kinetic	+1	Focuses spell on a single target.

Table F.3 – continued

Tag	Family	DV Mod	Effect
SUMMON	Creation	+2	Calls a spirit, elemental, or Outsider.
TRANSMUTE	Creation	+2	Changes one substance into another.
TRANSFORM	Creation	+2	Changes a creature's form.
VEIL	Mind	+1	Conceals from sight, memory, attention.
WAKEN	Life	+1	Rouses sleeping or stunned creature.
WALL	Kinetic	+1	Creates a barrier.
WAVE	Elemental	+1	Moves water or creates pressure.
WIND	Elemental	+1	Moves air.

Dangerous tags (DV +2) are marked in **red** in the main table.
The Weave charges a surcharge for these effects. Pay it or do not cast.

F.3 On Tag Combinations

Some tags work well together. [BURNING] and [AREA] produce a conflagration. [SILENCE] and [AREA] produce a zone of quiet. [LEAP] and [STRIKE] produce a teleporting attack—if you can manage the DV.

Some tags conflict. [HEAL] and [CURSE] cannot occupy the same spell; the Weave will choose one and ignore the other. [VEIL] and [REVEAL] cancel each other; the Weave will laugh and charge you for both.

Experiment in a safe space. Take notes. The Weave will not punish honest experimentation. It will punish carelessness.

— *Lysandra*

G Common Failures and Their Lessons

H Common Failures and Their Lessons

A ledger of mistakes I have made or witnessed. Each failure taught me something the Weave does not put in textbooks.

H.1 The Candle That Would Not Die

A novice attempted to extinguish a candle with [SILENCE]. He reasoned that sound and flame were connected. The Weave disagreed. The candle did not go out. It became *perfectly silent*—no crackle, no hiss, no pop—while burning twice as bright. The student learned: tags affect exactly what they name. [SILENCE] silences sound. It does not extinguish fire.

H.2 The Leap That Landed Wrong

I once cast [LEAP] to cross a chasm. I had cast the spell a hundred times. This time, I was tired, and I omitted the [WITNESS] tag that I usually included. The Weave obliged. I landed exactly where I intended. Unfortunately, the space where I intended to land was already occupied by a boulder that had not been there when I cast. The Weave had not moved the boulder. It had simply *not informed me*. I learned: a teleport is only as good as your knowledge of the destination. Scry before you leap.

H.3 The Healing That Hurt

A student in my care attempted [HEAL] on a wounded comrade. She rolled a miss. The Weave did not refuse to heal. It *transferred* the wound. The comrade's injury vanished. The student's arm opened with the same gash. She learned: the Weave balances ledgers. Healing is not creation; it is *movement*.

H.4 The Veil That Veiled Too Much

A confidence artist—not my student, thankfully—cast [VEIL] on his face during a negotiation. He wanted to make himself forgettable. The Weave obliged. His face blurred to the point that his own allies could not recognize him. The negotiation failed. He was stabbed by a guard who thought he was a different criminal. He survived. He learned: a veil should be measured. The Weave does not understand subtlety unless you specify.

H.5 The Gate That Opened Sideways

I have mentioned this failure elsewhere. A student cast [GATE] in an examination. The portal opened not to the adjacent hallway but to a room filled with mirrors. He saw versions of himself that had made different choices. He closed the portal. He withdrew from the University. He learned: the Weave's sense of destination is influenced by the caster's subconscious. If you are unsure of where you want to go, the Weave will guess. Its guesses are not kind.

H.6 The Summoning That Succeeded

A summoner—a colleague, not a student—called a spirit with [SUMMON]. The spirit arrived. It was exactly the spirit he had named. It was also, it turned out, the spirit of his own dead father, who had not spoken to him in life. The conversation lasted three hours. The summoner did not cast again for a year. He learned: a successful summoning is not necessarily a useful one. The Weave does not filter for comfort.

H.7 What These Failures Teach

- **Know your tags.** Each tag names exactly one quality. Do not assume synonyms.
- **Know your destination.** [LEAP] and [GATE] require current knowledge, not hope.
- **Healing is transfer.** The Weave does not create; it reallocates.
- **Measure your veils.** Too much concealment conceals you from your allies.
- **The Weave reads your subconscious.** Cast with a clear mind or accept the consequences.

The Weave is not a machine. It is a mirror. Failures teach you what the mirror sees.

— *Lysandra*

I A Short Lexicon of Thepyrgos Slang

J A Short Lexicon of Thepyrgos Slang for Casters

Every trade develops its own language. Free casting is no exception. The following terms are current among the Threadweavers of Thepyrgos—some borrowed from the University, some from the gutter, and a few that I invented myself.

J.1 Terms for the Caster

Threadweaver A free caster who shapes the raw Weave without patron or writ. Slightly derogatory when used by Runekeepers. A badge of honor when used by us.

Gutter- mage A Threadweaver who learned on the streets, not in a classroom. Often more skilled. Never more careful.

The Unlicensed What the Synod calls us. We call ourselves *the unburdened*.

Receipt Backlash. A minor receipt is a singed sleeve. A major receipt is a scar. A catastrophic receipt is a crater.

The Grammar The TAGS system. “*Study your Grammar.*” “*His Grammar is terrible.*”

J.2 Terms for Spells and Casting

Cantrip A one- tag spell. “*That’s just a cantrip. Anyone can light a candle.*”

Heavy Spell A spell with three or more tags. “*He’s throwing heavy spells now. Watch out for the receipt.*”

Folding Casting a dangerous tag, especially [FOLD] or [LEAP]. “*She folded out of the locked room.*”

The Surcharge The additional Difficulty for dangerous tags. “*The surcharge on [GATE] is worth it if you’re running from a mob.*”

Witness A third party who observes a casting. The Weave pays attention to witnesses. “*Always cast with a witness. The Weave lies less.*”

J.3 Terms for Failure and Backlash

The Weave's Humour A catastrophic failure. *"I rolled a miss. The Weave's humour was on full display."*

Singed Minor backlash. *"I'm singed, but I'll live."*

Interest A debt incurred by repeated failures. *"I've paid too much interest on that spell. I'm not casting it again."*

The Ledger A caster's personal record of failures. *"Check the ledger before you try that. I've seen it go wrong."*

J.4 Terms for the Weave Itself

The Old Conversation The relationship between caster and Weave. *"She has a good Old Conversation going. The Weave listens to her."*

The Receipt Book The Weave's own record of every spell ever cast. Apocryphal. Believed in by those who have cast dangerous tags.

The Surcharge King A joking name for any tag that adds DV +2. *"[LEAP] is the Surcharge King. [TRANSFORM] is his queen."*

J.5 Conversational Examples

'How was the examination?'

'Singed. I attempted a heavy spell without a witness.'

'The Weave's humour?'

'A minor receipt. My sleeve will recover.'

'Why didn't you fold out of the ambush?'

'The surcharge was too high. I was already carrying interest from a previous miss.'

'She's a natural.'

'She's a gutter-mage. Same thing.'

The Old Conversation The relationship between caster and Weave. *"She has a good Old Conversation going. The Weave listens to her."*

The Receipt Book The Weave's own record of every spell ever cast. Apocryphal. Believed in by those who have cast dangerous tags.

The Surcharge King A joking name for any tag that adds DV +2. *"[LEAP] is the Surcharge King. [TRANSFORM] is his queen."*

Burn To cast a spell recklessly, without regard for backlash. *"He burned a [GATE] with no witness. The Weave's humour was not kind."*

Cold Casting A spell performed with no witnesses, relying solely on the caster's precision. *"Cold casting [VEIL] is fine. Cold casting [REWIND] is suicide."*

The Unwritten Line The gap between what the caster intends and what the Weave hears. “*Every miss teaches you something about the Unwritten Line.*”

J.6 A Dialog from the Amber Gate

Two Threadweavers meet after an examination.

“How did you fare?”
 “Singed. I attempted a heavy [FOLD] without a witness.”
 “The Weave’s humour?”
 “A minor receipt. My sleeve will recover. You?”
 “Cold cast [SCRY] to find the exit. Clean success. No receipt.”
 “Show-off.”
 “The Weave prefers precision. You know that.”
 “The Weave also prefers courage. Singed is not failed.”
 “True. Buy me a drink and I’ll show you my ledger.”

Language shapes practice. Learn the slang. It will help you sound like you know what you are doing—even when you do not.

— *Lysandra*

K The Examination of the Amber Gate

L The Examination of the Amber Gate

A sample scenario for Game Masters. This is the practical examination I give to my advanced students. It is not a combat. It is a test of grammar, judgement, and the willingness to accept a receipt.

L.1 Setup

The candidate stands in a sealed chamber. The chamber has one door, currently locked. On a table in the center of the room rests a single candle—unlit. On the wall opposite the door hangs a mirror. The mirror reflects the candidate's face, but the reflection is slightly delayed.

The candidate is told: *“Leave the room. You may not touch the door. You may not break the mirror. The candle is your only tool. You have until the candle burns out.”*

The candle is not magical. It will burn for exactly one scene.

L.2 The Challenge

The door is locked with a mundane lock. The candidate cannot touch the door. The mirror is a *witness*. The Weave will remember anything the mirror sees.

The candidate must use the candle and the mirror to unlock the door from a distance. There are multiple solutions.

L.2.1 Solution One: Veil and Leap

The candidate casts [VEIL] on the candle's flame, making it invisible to the mirror. The mirror does not witness the next action. The candidate then casts [LEAP] to teleport their own hand through the door (line of sight required—but the door is wood; they cannot see through it). This fails unless they also cast [SCRY] to see the far side. Three tags. DV 5. Risky.

L.2.2 Solution Two: Memory and Mirror

The candidate lights the candle. The mirror reflects the flame. The candidate casts [MEMORY] on the mirror, instructing it to *forget* that the door is locked. The Weave accepts this if the candidate has touched the lock previously (so the mirror has a memory of it unlocked). DV 4. Requires preparation.

L.2.3 Solution Three: The Direct Approach

The candidate casts [TRANSFORM] on the lock, turning it into wax. The lock melts. The door opens. The mirror witnesses everything. The Weave charges a receipt for the transformation. The candidate accepts it. DV 5 (dangerous). Simple. Expensive.

L.2.4 Solution Four: The Student Who Read the Assignment

The candidate notices that the instruction says “*You may not touch the door. You may not break the mirror. The candle is your only tool.*” It does not say the candidate cannot ask for help. The candidate knocks. The examiner opens the door from the outside.

The candidate passes with highest honors.

L.3 Scoring

- **Clean success (any solution):** Pass.
- **Partial success:** Pass with a note to review tag combinations.
- **Miss, minor receipt:** Retake in one month.
- **Miss, major receipt:** Retake after remedial Grammar.
- **Catastrophic failure:** The examination hall is on fire. The candidate is awarded a passing grade for spectacle.

L.4 GM Notes

This examination tests creative problem- solving, not combat. Encourage players to propose unusual tag combinations. Reward clever interpretations of the instructions. The Weave respects cleverness almost as much as it respects precision.

If the candidate sets the mirror on fire, the mirror will remember. The Weave will include that memory in its receipt.

— *Lysandra*

M The Caster's Ledger

N The Caster's Ledger

A spell you cast once is a demonstration. A spell you cast twice is a habit. A spell you record is a *tool*. The Weave does not care whether you write things down, but you should. Memory is a poor ledger. Paper is patient.

This appendix provides a template for building your own grimoire—a personal record of the spells you have learned, invented, or stolen. I have left space for the spell's name, its tags, its intended effect, and a note on what the Weave said in reply. The last column is the most important.

N.1 How to Use This Ledger

Before you cast a new spell, write down your intention. Name the tags. Estimate the Difficulty. This is not a contract; it is a *hypothesis*.

After you cast, record what happened. Did the Weave comply? Did it comment? Did it laugh? Write that down too.

Over time, you will notice patterns. Some tags work well together. Some elements produce reliable backlash. Some spells fail in instructive ways. Your ledger will become a map of your relationship with the Weave.

I have kept such a ledger for forty years. It is thicker than my arm. I do not carry it; it carries me.

N.2 Spell Card Template

The following page contains a template for a spell card. You may photocopy it, trace it, or simply write its contents in a notebook. I have provided a sample entry to illustrate the form.

N.2.1 Sample Entry

Spell Name: Ember Flick	
Tags	[BURNING] [STRIKE]
Intended Effect	Ignite a small flammable object within Close range. A candle, a twist of paper, a dry leaf. Not a person.
Difficulty (estimated)	3 (two tags, no dangerous surcharge)
Outcome & Backlash	Clean success: the leaf ignites. Minor backlash on a partial: a spark jumps to the caster's sleeve (1 Fatigue).
Notes	The Weave is precise about what it considers "flammable." Wet leaves do not count. Do not argue.

N.2.2 Blank Spell Card

Reproduce this card as many times as you need. I recommend a stout paper and a pencil with a good eraser. The Weave appreciates correction.

Spell Name:	
Tags	
Intended Effect	
Difficulty (estimated)	
Outcome & Backlash	
Notes	

N.3 Advanced Ledger: The Spell Chain

Some spells are not single castings. They are sequences—a [VEIL] followed by a [LEAP] followed by a [SILENCE]. The Weave treats each step as a separate transaction, but you may record the chain as a single entry.

N.3.1 Sample Chain: The Quiet Exit

Chain Name: The Quiet Exit	
Step 1	[VEIL] on self. DV 2. Blur features.
Step 2	[SILENCE] on footsteps. DV 2. Muffle sound.
Step 3	[LEAP] to exit. DV 4 (dangerous). Teleport to visible exit.
Total Risk	Each step carries its own backlash. A failure in Step 3 does not undo Step 1. The Weave respects sequence.
Notes	Practice the chain in a safe room before attempting it in a guarded hallway. I speak from experience.

N.4 The Ledger's Discipline

A student once showed me his spell ledger. It was beautiful—leather binding, gold leaf, neat calligraphy. He had recorded every spell he had ever cast, including the ones that failed.

I asked him, *“Do you read it?”*

He said, *“I wrote it. I do not need to read it.”*

He was wrong. A ledger that is not consulted is a monument, not a tool. A ledger that is consulted is a conversation with your past self. The Weave listens when you learn from your own mistakes.

N.4.1 Monthly Review

Once a month, read your ledger from cover to cover. Note which spells succeed reliably. Note which spells fail in interesting ways. Note which spells you have not cast since you wrote them down—and ask yourself why.

N.4.2 The Weave's Marginalia

Sometimes the Weave adds its own notes. I have opened my ledger to find a word underlined in a hand that was not mine. I have seen a page that was blank become filled with a single sentence: “*You forgot the [WITNESS].*”

The Weave does not vandalise. It *edits*. Welcome the edits.

N.5 A Final Card for the Road

Carry one blank card with you at all times. When you cast a spell you have never cast before, write it down immediately—the tags, the intent, the backlash. Do this while the Weave's receipt is still warm.

The card will become a record of your most desperate moments. Those are the moments that teach the most.

Emergency Spell	
Tags	
Intended Effect	
Difficulty	
Backlash Observed	
Date	

— *Lysandra*

Colophon

This book was written on paper that had been a customs manifest, a rejected petition for readmission to the Synod's good graces, and a letter from a student who set fire to her own desk. The ink is lamp- black cut with the ash of a burnt syllabus and a single drop of my own blood—for luck, not for binding. The binding is the spine of a disgraced scholar's own dissertation. The margins contain marginalia from three of my students. I have not erased it. They earned the space.

The Weave does not forget. Neither do I.

If you have read this far, you have already begun. Light a candle. Name a tag. Roll the dice. The backlash is yours.

I have taught for forty years. I have seen students become masters, masters become legends, and legends become cautionary tales. I have no idea which of those categories I belong to. The Weave does not tell me. It only sends receipts.

One final piece of advice: when the Weave speaks, listen. When it laughs, laugh with it. When it demands payment, pay. And when it offers you a receipt, keep it. You will need it for your own ledger.

The road is south. The lamp is borrowed. The ink is fresh.

— *Lysandra of the Amber Gate Thepyrgos, in the hour before the eighth bell The candle is still burning.*